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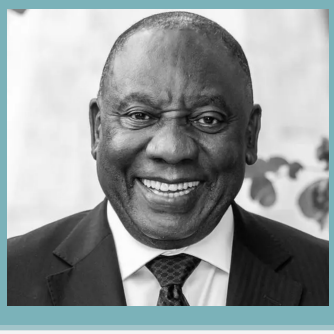

Cyril Ramaphosa

(ram-ah-PO-sah)

President of the Republic of South Africa

Addressed as: **Mr. President** | Office held since: **Feb. 2018**

An optimistic and congenial leader, Ramaphosa is struggling to reconcile his storied reputation as a bold dealmaker with his recent record as a hesitant decisionmaker.

- **The Dealmaker**
  Ramaphosa built his reputation as a master negotiator during the transition to democracy and later as a successful businessman. He leveraged his skills to vault himself over rivals in his quest to become president in 2018 and form a coalition with the opposition in 2024.

- **The Vacillator**
  Ramaphosa's overreliance on consultation and perceived hesitancy to make commitments have drawn criticism from those expecting more decisive leadership in the face of steep economic challenges and rising U.S. pressure.

Ramaphosa frequently cites South Africa's negotiated transition and unique history as sources of inspiration. He believes South African values–such as solidarity, integrity, and dialogue–hold the key to solving the most vexing foreign and domestic problems.

WHY THEY MATTER

Ramaphosa is focused on attracting foreign investment to address his country's economic woes, asking companies to partner in support of his country's developmental agenda.

- **Reviving the Economy**
  Ramaphosa in 2024 pledged to strengthen the economy by extending prosperity to the poor, reviving factories and farms, building roads, and investing in infrastructure.

- **Increasing Financial Inclusion**
  Ramaphosa has prioritized expanding access to banking and financial services, seeing it as crucial for empowering youth- and women-owned enterprises. He wants basic infrastructure and services to reach underserved communities.

As South Africa holds the G20 presidency this year, Ramaphosa is touting his country as the premier entry point to the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) and the broader 1.4 billion-person African market.

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MEETING WITH THEM

A warm and gregarious interlocutor, Ramaphosa believes that his patient approach, personal appeals, and thoughtful explanations will persuade his counterparts.

- **Finding Common Ground**
  Ramaphosa seeks out opportunities to connect, often talking up mutual experiences, similar hobbies, and shared values. He uses inclusive language and emotional appeals to make his case.

- **Sharing Essential Context**
  Ramaphosa wants his counterparts to understand his reasoning, launching into short monologues about constraints, process, and historical context.

Ramaphosa's meeting with President Trump in May displayed many of his talents, including strategic deployment of humor and rapport-building over shared interests like golf. At the same time, Ramaphosa spoke far less than usual and opted for shorter, more defensive responses rather than expansive explanations.

ON THEIR MIND

- **U.S. Tariffs & AGOA**
  Ramaphosa recently sent a trade delegation to negotiate with U.S. counterparts after Trump imposed a 30 percent tariff. He also wants to see an extension of the African Growth and Opportunity Act (AGOA), which is set to expire this month.

- **G20 Chairmanship**
  As part of South Africa's G20 presidency, Ramaphosa will host his global counterparts in November. With the theme of "Solidarity. Equality. Sustainability," Ramaphosa is pushing for reforms to global governance.

- **National Dialogue**
  In August, Ramaphosa launched a national dialogue "to reflect on the state of our country in order for us to reimagine our future." Critics have raised questions about the $40 million price tag while opposition parties, including coalition partner the Democratic Alliance (DA), have withdrawn from the process.

- **South Africa's Record Win in Rugby Match**
  South Africa's Springboks dealt a devastating blow to New Zealand on September 13, defeating their archrivals by 43-10 to revive their Rugby Championship campaign. South Africa will play Argentina on September 27.

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NETWORK

Ramaphosa, who views South Africa as a major global player, is finding it hard to preserve his country's non-aligned status in an increasingly complex, contested, and chaotic world.

Ramaphosa defends his close relationships with China and Russia, and his decision to take Israel to the International Court of Justice for its actions in Gaza. Under pressure from the United States, however, he has tempered his country's foreign ties, opting out of an annual military exercise with China and Russia and scolding his Army Chief for positive comments about Iran.

Ramaphosa is saddled with contentious domestic relations, trying to hold together an unstable coalition with the opposition and seeking to manage constant backbiting within the ruling African National Congress.

Since the 2004 election, Ramaphosa and his coalition partners have fought over parliamentary bills and the management of specific ministries. The president also is battling factionalism and rampant corruption within his own party. His allies and rivals are already positioning themselves to replace him at the party's elective conference in 2027.

CONTROVERSIES

Ramaphosa, while less sullied by corruption or controversies compared to his predecessor, has been under a cloud for personal scandals, foreign policy crises, and economic failures.

- **Phala Phala Scandal**
  Allegations surrounding foreign currency theft at Ramaphosa's game farm have damaged his anti-corruption credentials. While preliminary investigations cleared him of a conflict of interest, the scandal contributed to public disillusionment and the ANC's electoral losses.

- **Foreign Policy Crises**
  Ramaphosa's positions on the Russian war in Ukraine, Israeli actions in Gaza, and military cooperation with China have landed him in hot water with U.S. officials. Trump's false accusation of a "white genocide" in South Africa has further damaged the bilateral relationship.

  Critics argue that despite his business background, Ramaphosa has failed to significantly reduce unemployment or accelerate economic growth. The ANC's electoral losses in 2024 were partly attributed to economic frustrations.

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CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **President**, Government of South Africa (2018 - present)
- **Deputy President**, Government of South Africa (2014 to 2018)
- **Co-Founder**, Shanduka Group (1996 to 2012)
- **Chairman**, Constitutional Assembly (1994 to 1996)
- **Secretary-General**, African National Congress (1991 to 1996)
- **General Secretary**, National Union of Mineworkers (NUM) (1982 to 1991)

BIO

Ramaphosa's journey from trade unionist to businessman to president reflects South Africa's post-apartheid transformation. Born November 17, 1952, in Johannesburg, he studied law at University of the North (Turfloop), became an anti-apartheid activist, and spent 11 months in solitary confinement in 1974.

- **Labor Leader, Negotiator, Business Magnate**
  Ramaphosa led the National Union of Mineworkers in the 1980s and later was tapped by Nelson Mandela to help negotiate the end of apartheid. Initially viewed as a potential successor to Mandela, he ended up in business with financial stakes in mining, energy, banking, and McDonald's South Africa.

- **Sports and Cattle Farming**
  Ramaphosa understands the unifying power of sports, cheering on South Africa's Springboks and Proteas, as well as expressing interest in golf and netball. He is an avid walker and has a passion for breeding Ankole cattle.

Ramaphosa is married to Dr. Tshepo Motsepe, a physician and businesswoman, and has five children. He belongs to the Christian faith, which he admires for its message of humility and service. He speaks English, as well as several South African languages, including his native Venda.

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